# Inside the Minds of $1B Brand Founders

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## 📋 Executive Summary

A behind-the-scenes vlog from the 2026 Founders Land event in Malibu where billion-dollar brand founders share raw lessons on bootstrapping, in-house operations, brand longevity, Q4 strategy, and the founder mindset.

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## 🏖️ Setting the Scene: Founders Land Malibu 2026 0:42

- Founders Land is described as a massive annual event held in Malibu
  - Greg calls it a gathering of "legends in this room"
  - The premise: bring together exceptional founders outside conventional systems and "amazing things will happen"
- Key attendees introduced throughout the vlog:
  - **Ross McKay** — co-founder of Cadence, a fast-growing performance hydration brand launched in 2024 with George Heaton
  - **Mari Llewellyn** — visionary co-founder of Bloom Nutrition
  - **Adam Goldberg** — founder of Pop-Up Bagels, a multi-million dollar bagel brand started from his backyard in 2020
  - **George Heaton** — co-founder of Represent, a global British fashion brand worth over $100 million
  - **Alana Chun** — 21-year-old co-founder and CEO of Base (hair and body care brand), valued at $200M+, co-built with influencer Lance Baker

- **Hudson Leogrand** — founder of Comfort, a fast-growing apparel brand doing nine-figure annual revenue

- A humorous aside: LeBron James appears wearing a "Bloom Energy" jersey for the Philadelphia 76ers — Greg clarifies this is a different company (an AI energy sourcing company), not his Bloom Nutrition brand

## 🌿 Bloom Nutrition: Building a Billion-Dollar Wellness Brand by Bootstrapping 2:49

- Greg and Mari Lavecchia (married co-founders) built Bloom Nutrition into a billion-dollar wellness brand
- **Origin story:**
  - Started as a personal health transformation initiative
  - Grew into a global movement inspiring millions to take control of their health
  - Early headquarters: a one-bedroom, one-bathroom Airbnb in Santa Monica
    - First 8 employees worked out of that single apartment — all sharing one bathroom
  - First major HQ was a 10,000 sq ft space; Greg describes signing the 5-year lease as terrifying
- **Bootstrapping philosophy:**
  - Greg and Mari never considered fundraising or taking on a partner early on
  - "I don't think we even knew what enterprise value was" — they had zero awareness of funding mechanics
  - They competed in greens against AG1, which had a $1 billion valuation and a network of agencies
  - Response: built a more efficient **in-house model** — influencer agency, branding agency, and R&D team all internal
    - This allowed them to outcompete brands writing much larger checks at a fraction of the cost
- **Beverage launch decision:**
  - When Bloom grew large enough to enter beverages, they knew DIY would take too long and risk costly mistakes
  - Chose to partner with DOS (Doshi), who understood beverages and helped execute in ~6 months
  - Greg calls this "one of the best decisions we ever made"
  - DOS's acquisition of Bloom included acquiring the in-house influencer agency, branding agency, and R&D team
- **Current revenue breakdown (2026 projections):**

| Product Line | Estimated Revenue |
|---|---|
| Energy Drinks | $600M+ |
| Bloom Pop (healthy soda) | ~$150M |
| Nutrition (greens, etc.) | ~$130M |

- **Strategic lessons Greg shares on stage:**

    - "Don't reinvent the wheel — improve it" — second-mover advantage is real; energy drinks and healthy soda are the largest portfolio segments
    - "Speed kills and move at the pace of culture" — transitioning from a nimble speedboat to a cruise ship is the hardest phase
    - Example of cultural agility: when Drake released an album, they could immediately launch a matching product tied to the cultural moment; now at scale, that's much harder
    - Competing against Red Bull, Celsius, Monster who have F1, FIFA World Cup, Super Bowl partnerships — Bloom can never match those checks
        - What those brands don't have: Valentine's Day activations, nimble seasonal partnership plays
        - Example cited: partnering with a Disney Thanksgiving movie release to launch a new grape soda as fast as possible
- **Advice to founders — anti-dilution strategy:**
    - Bootstrapping as long as possible is strongly recommended
    - Fundraising was never on their radar; they didn't know what enterprise value meant
    - Being resource-constrained forced them to build a better, cheaper in-house system

## 💡 Greg's Advice to His Younger Self: Stress Is Not a Success Ingredient 4:54

- Greg's core lesson to 2019-era Greg:

> "Stress and anxiety are not direct or necessary components of productivity and winning."

    - In 2019 he believed stress was essential to success — he now sees this as wrong
    - Chronic stress leads to **more emotional decisions** and **fewer rational decisions**
    - Managing stress as a founder directly protects physical health and decision quality
- On ambition vs. guilt:
    - Older generations try to guilt younger generations for always wanting more
    - Greg reframes this: not wanting more is actually **disrespecting the opportunity** this generation has been given
    - "If you're not giving your all to contribute the most you can to society — in my case through business — you're actually disrespecting the opportunity at hand"
    - Wanting more is not greed; it is gratitude for the opportunity
- On comparing your year 2 to someone else's year 8–9:
    - Common mistake among founders at events like Founders Land
    - Greg has been building this community for 11 years; Bloom is in year 8–9
    - Advice: compare your year 2 to their year 2 — you may actually be bigger
    - The real goal was never to beat other founders on Instagram; it was freedom, a great team, contribution to society, and a full life

## 🥯 Pop-Up Bagels: From Home Kitchen to 49-Outlet Bagel Empire 6:51

- **Adam Goldberg**, founder of Pop-Up Bagels
  - Started in his backyard during COVID (late 2020)
  - Now sells bagels across **49 outlets**; no cream cheese on the bagel — just hot bagels straight from the oven in a bag
  - "The fastest-growing franchises right now are very simple, simple, simple"
- **Origin story — cottage license hustle:**
  - Started selling from home with a cottage license, sometimes borrowing a friend's restaurant
  - Name "Pop-Up Bagel" came from this pop-up, borrowed-kitchen model
  - In February 2021, the State of Connecticut called: "Congratulations, your cottage license has expired because you exceeded $10,000 in sales" — given 30 days to find a new kitchen
- **Creative kitchen deal:**
  - Found a restaurant owner willing to lend his kitchen on weekends — no rent paid directly
  - Structure: Adam sells a dozen bagels; customer must buy 2 cream cheeses at $12 from the restaurant owner
  - Predicted 100 dozen on a Saturday; within 2 months expanded to Friday, Saturday, and Sunday
  - The restaurant owner ended up making **$7,000–$10,000 per weekend** just on cream cheese
  - This translated to Adam paying the equivalent of **$25,000–$30,000/month** in indirect rent through cream cheese sales
- **Key lesson on favors:**
  - "When you're young and before you understand what you need, don't spend your favors too early"
  - When he needed real funding and to bring in a Hollywood producer, he had saved up his social capital
  - Sent bagels by mail; producer said "they're fine"; Adam invented a reason to be in LA, cooked at a friend Jack's place — Jack had no idea until the call
  - "I saved all my favors for when the business started" — used connections strategically at scale moments
  - "People support good. People support good people."

## 🏃 George Heaton & Represent: The Case for Full-Wardrobe Brand Strategy 13:31

- **George Heaton**, co-founder of Represent — a global British fashion brand worth **$100M+**
  - Also co-founded Cadence (performance hydration) with Ross McKay
- **On personal brand:**
  - "Personal branding is a full-time job, out of control"
  - Built his page with no expectations; since March (last meeting), revenue has **doubled**
  - No Twitter presence; uses voice-to-text for all communication
- **The menswear gap and activewear thesis:**

    - Today's billion-dollar fashion brands are athleisure and sportswear
    - Challenge: name a menswear brand doing $150M+ that is less than 50 years old — George says none exist in his market
    - Friends with newer brands all plateau at $30–40M because there's a ceiling on how many young clothes-buyers you can capture
    - Solution: activewear expands the addressable market beyond fashion buyers into performance/gym buyers
- **Full-wardrobe retention strategy:**
    - If Represent can dress a customer from gym wear to evening wear to footwear, return customer rate beats any single-category brand
    - "Where does he go for the rest of his clothes? Where does he go to the gym? Where does he go out at night? What shoes does he want?"
    - Loyalty is built by owning the entire wardrobe
    - Current question: how to grow that customer base 10x
- **Product portfolio and patience:**
    - Has failed many times at shoes, denim, and various categories over 15 years
    - "It takes 10 years to perfect denim" — once it works, the pipeline is already built
    - Fashion brands typically stay popular for **~3 years** — having a diversified pipeline means when one category dips, another rises
    - Product pipeline is currently planned through **Autumn/Winter 2028** — including speed suits for 2028 Olympics athletes
- **Core business economics:**
    - ~25% of Represent's business is now sportswear (24/7 line), launched only 4 years ago
    - The halo product (luxury, distressed, expensive items like heavy washed leather) attracts customers who then buy the entry-level hoodies
    - "Sounds like a pig, drives like a minibus" — luxury attracts, basics profit
    - Hoodies and t-shirts make up 60% of any person's wardrobe — that's where the real business is
- **On outdoor/functional brand strategy (Salomon, Arc'teryx, North Face):**
    - These brands maintain mountain/outdoor imagery even though rappers and urban culture wear their products
    - Salomon prioritizes rock-climbing functionality over mainstream appeal, even at the cost of billions in broader revenue
    - George's take: this identity preservation is actually smart — "everyone wants to pretend they're using functional things"

## 👗 Comfort & Hudson Leogrand: Q4 Scaling and Retail Innovation 26:19

- **Hudson Leogrand**, founder of Comfort (9-figure annual revenue apparel brand)
    - Expanding into home goods: blankets, pillows, comforters — targeting **$1B+ in home delivery**

    - Launched ahead of Black Friday; sales up **30% on Thursday alone** after early launch
- **Q4 advertising strategy — start early:**
    - Media buying team sees consumer sentiment trending down; expects a **slower Black Friday** this year
    - Competitors all scale up at the same time during Q4 — ad auctions become extremely competitive
    - Comfort's counter-strategy: be 2 months in before Black Friday when everyone else is just starting
    - "By the time you're scaling up for Black Friday, I've been there for two months"
    - On Meta ad auction dynamics during Q4:
        - When everyone bids simultaneously, auction competitiveness peaks — best prices go to whoever got there first
        - Bid caps and cost caps become the only lever left for latecomers
- **Meta ad scaling best practices (discussed with Greg):**
    - Never spike ad spend suddenly — going from $100K to $500K/day in one jump triggers Meta's fraud detection
    - If an account is flagged, you're stuck with no Meta support during a critical weekend
    - **Correct approach:** increase budget by maximum **10% per day**
        - Going from $100K/day to $1M+/day takes approximately **2 months** at this pace
        - Exceeding 10% daily increase pushes campaigns back into a learning phase, resetting algorithm efficiency
    - Ensure your Meta rep knows about planned spend increases in advance
- **Retail store concept — Mall of America & American Dream:**
    - Opening at Mall of America and American Dream mall
    - Each location is a **live studio** where creators can go live while customers shop in-store
    - When a TikTok flash sale goes live, the entire physical store simultaneously goes on flash sale
    - Example: "You know Brook will be live from American Dream from 4–7 PM Wednesday; if you're there in person, you get better deals"
    - In-store exclusives include limited edition colorways
    - Plans to stock Bloom and other founder-friends' brands in the retail locations
    - Gamifying the retail experience — blending online and in-person in real time
- **On consumer spending resilience:**
    - Despite bearish sentiment forecasts: "We are American. Even if the world is on fire, we'll probably say 'buy buy buy'"
    - BNPL (Buy Now Pay Later) companies are "printing money" — half of all online purchases under $100 are now BNPL
    - Consumerism is at an all-time high despite macro pessimism

## 🧠 Founder Mindset: Competition, Ambition, and Defining Your Own Win 15:01

- George Heaton on timeline expectations for new founders:

    - If you're 20 and want to reach this level, it will take **10–20 years**
    - Danger of social media: seeing Greg's Instagram perform well for 1–2 years and thinking you can replicate it in 1–2 years
    - Even if you get there fast, build slowly and steadily — "build a brand that's truly purposeful and meaningful, and when you turn off your ads, the brand is still alive"
    - George: "I've been doing this 15 years and I'm nowhere near what this guy has achieved, but I know I'm building something that will last my entire life"
    - Key question: where do you want to be in 20–30 years, and will your brand be with you then? Avoid cycling back to zero every 2 years
- Greg on legacy and family:
    - His son is young enough that if Bloom were ever sold, the son might not even remember it
    - Greg has documented key moments: son touching products at Target, mom shown on a POS end cap display
    - "The experiences are what really matter" — not the money
    - What he wants to leave his son (Kai) in a will: **knowledge and wisdom**, not just financial assets — so Kai doesn't make the same painful mistakes
- Greg on networking:
    - Previously believed early-career networking was a waste of time — view partially unchanged
    - But when you enter rooms by contributing value, networking becomes genuinely powerful
    - Founders Land 2026 has opened massive opportunities through this model

## 💊 Telehealth & Biohacking: The "Superhuman Stack" Discussion 30:27

- Leo is researching the telehealth space; discussion of the "2TM Stack" (Superhuman Stack):
    - **Tirzepatide** (GLP-1 agonist — weight/metabolic)
    - **Testosterone** (dosage still being determined)
    - **Modafinil** — used by fighter pilots and military to stay awake; described as "not caffeine, but it keeps you awake"
- Humorous aside: Greg jokes about launching "Moonshot Labs" to sell the Superhuman Stack
    - "If anyone has used the Superhuman Stack, let me know how many days it took you to get to the hospital. If it's more than 45 days, I'll try it."
- Companies in the telehealth space are noted to be selling these compounds; question raised about regulatory permissibility

## 🚀 Q4 Urgency: 90 Days to Build the Foundation for 2027 23:49

- Greg's core thesis: **2026 is the warmup; 2027 is the real year**
    - Everything learned in 2026 compounds into the best possible 2027
    - "If I get a full year of 2027 built on everything I've learned in 2026, 2027 is going to be insane"

- Q4 = 90 days remaining to lay the foundation
  - Best ideas in Greg's 11-year career went from concept to live on Shopify/TikTok Shop in **90 days**
  - A person who has never started a business can become a company owner selling online within 90 days
  - While everyone else slows down for Thanksgiving and Halloween, this is exactly when you can gain the most ground on competitors
- **Product opportunity Greg highlights:** Condiments/sauces — specifically honey mustard
  - Honey mustard, ketchup, mustard, relish, mayo are massive, boring categories ripe for premiumization
  - Strategy: make them slightly healthier, slightly more natural, slightly better packaging
  - "Sometimes the obvious answer is the right answer"
  - Caution to founders comparing themselves to more established brands: compare year 2 to year 2, not year 2 to year 9
- **Powder vs. liquid product economics lesson:**
  - Greg's advice to young founders pitching a canned mocktail margarita mix (no alcohol, sold on Shopify):
    - Suggested launching a **powder version** alongside
    - Shipping cost comparison: **$25 to ship a drink** vs. **$2.50 for a powder sachet**
    - The savings go directly into advertising budget
    - "I only recommend things we do ourselves" — Bloom Energy drink business is 10% stick packets
  - Broader point: powder companies think they can't make drinks; drink companies think they can't make powder — both are wrong
    - Cadence's best-selling product is a **sleep powder**
    - Early-stage founders with no retail distribution should avoid e-commerce beverages; powders are far more economics-friendly